FOR STUDENTS DESIGNING A PLINKO THEME

Plinko Game Guide

How a game goes, how the board works, what every power-up does, and how to plan your own power-ups so they fit the game.



The game at a glance

Part	How it works
Players	1 to 5 on one iPad: you, classmates in the room, and Neighbors. Everyone takes turns.
Rounds	3 to 10 (5 is the usual). One round means every player has had one turn.
Questions	1 to 5 questions before each drop. A wrong answer brings a new question until one is right. Then you drop.
Score	XP. The bucket your ball lands in is the XP you get. Most XP at the end wins.
Money	Every right answer still earns your usual class money.

One turn, step by step

1. **Whose turn.** A big card shows the player and the round.
2. **Answer.** Get the question right to earn your drop.
3. **Pick a power-up.** Only after the question is answered, and only if you landed on a star in the round before. You get one power-up, used this turn. Power-ups never save for later rounds.
4. **Aim.** Tap a numbered drop zone across the top of the board.
5. **Drop.** The ball falls through 7 rows of pegs. On each row it bounces half a space left or right, by chance.
6. **Land.** The bucket gives you XP. A star on that bucket is a power-up for your next turn.

7. **Extra drops.** If a power-up gave you one, you aim and drop again right away, with no new question.
8. **Next player.** When everyone has gone, a new round starts and the board grows.

The board grows every round

Round	Drop zones	Buckets	Bucket points	Peg types (if the theme has them)
1	5	3	10 to 30	1
2	6	4	10 to 40	2
3	7	5	10 to 50	3
4	8	6	10 to 60	4
5	9	7	10 to 70	5
6 and up	10	8	10 to 80	one more each round

- Bucket points are mixed into a new order at the start of every round, so the best bucket moves.
- **Stars:** the top bucket never has a star. Smaller buckets are more likely to have one. There is always at least one bucket with a star.
- **Pegs:** every peg the ball hits pops away and gives XP. A plain peg is worth 1 XP. The peg color from round 1 is worth 1 XP, the color that joins in round 2 is worth 2 XP, and so on. A popped peg leaves a gap the ball falls straight through. Popped pegs come back at the start of the next round.
- That makes aiming a choice: big points now, or power-ups for your next turn.

How points are counted

XP for a drop = bucket points × every multiplier, then + every bonus, then + peg XP

Example: the ball lands in 30 with Double on and a +20 bonus: 30 × 2 = 60, then 60 + 20 = 80 XP.

The four main power-ups

Every power-up in every theme follows the same four rules: **what it does**, **when it works**, **how the ball moves**, and **how it works with other power-ups**. A theme can rename a main power-up and give it a new picture, but it always keeps its action.

All power-ups: one per round, won with a star in the round before, picked after your question, before you aim, on for this whole turn (extra drops included), then gone. They never save.



Double `MULTIPLY, TIMES 2`

What it does	The bucket counts twice. A 30 bucket gives 60.
When it works	Every drop this turn, extra drops too.
How the ball moves	No change.
With others	Multipliers multiply each other (times 2 and times 3 make times 6). Bonuses are added after, so they are never doubled.



Big Ball `BIG BALL`

What it does	The ball is bigger and heavier, so where you drop it matters more.
When it works	Every drop this turn.
How the ball moves	On each row there is a 1 in 2 chance it falls straight down instead of bouncing.
With others	On the rows where it does bounce, a Magnet can still pull it.



Magnet `PULL TO THE TOP BUCKET`

What it does	Pulls the ball toward the bucket worth the most points.
When it works	Every drop this turn.
How the ball moves	On each row there is a 3 in 4 chance it bounces toward the top bucket. It can still miss.
With others	With Big Ball, some rows fall straight and the magnet pulls on the others. Works with multipliers and bonuses.



Double Ball Drop `TWO BALLS`

What it does	Two balls drop from the same zone at once and each one bounces its own way. Both score.
When it works	Every drop this turn.
How the ball moves	Each ball moves the usual way, on its own path. A theme can draw both balls.
With others	Every other power-up works on both balls (Double doubles both). A star in either bucket gives one power-up for the next round.

More actions a theme can use

A theme can add its own power-ups. Each new one picks an action from this list (with its amount), or, if none fits, describes something new.

Action	Amount	The four rules in short
Growing ball	none	Starts small and grows every row. The bigger it gets, the more it falls straight (up to 1 in 2 on the bottom rows). Every drop this turn.
Pop	none	Just above the buckets it pops in a burst and lands in the best of the three closest buckets. Every drop this turn.
Heavy ball	none	Falls fast and mostly straight: 3 in 4 chance to fall straight on each row. Every drop this turn.
Extra bouncy ball	none	Bounces a full space on every peg instead of half a space. Anything can happen. Every drop this turn.
Two balls	none	Two balls drop from the same zone, each on its own path. Both score, and every other power-up works on both.
Multiply the points	times 2 to 5	Bucket counts that many times. Every drop this turn. Ball moves as usual. Multipliers multiply each other.
Bonus XP	5 to 100 XP	Adds XP wherever it lands. Every drop this turn. Ball moves as usual. Added after multipliers; bonuses add together.
Big ball	none	1 in 2 chance to fall straight on each row. Every drop this turn.
Magnet	none	3 in 4 chance to bounce toward the top bucket on each row. Every drop this turn.
Extra drops	1 to 3 drops	Drop again right away. Other power-ups stay on. Two extra-drop power-ups add up.
Never the lowest bucket	none	If the ball would land in the lowest bucket, it rolls to the better bucket beside it, then multipliers and bonuses count as usual.
Something new	you decide	You write all four rules. It is saved, but students only see it after it is built into the game.

When power-ups mix

When several power-ups are on, the game always uses them in this order:

1. **The fall.** On each row, Heavy, Big and Growing balls check first (fall straight?). If the ball bounces, it moves half a space (a full space if Extra bouncy), and Magnet

decides the direction.

2. **The landing.** Pop picks the best of the three closest buckets. Then Never the lowest bucket moves the ball over, if it is on.
3. **Multipliers.** All of them multiply the bucket.
4. **Bonuses.** All of them are added last.
5. **Two balls.** Each ball does steps 1 to 4 on its own, and both scores add up.
6. **Extra drops.** Start again from step 1, with the same power-ups on.

Neighbors

Neighbors answer by themselves, pick their power-ups at random, and drop in a random zone. They follow every other rule the same way you do.

Peg colors and music

A theme can have up to 20 peg types, each with its own color and sound (a bark, a boing). Each round one more type joins the board, picked at random, and is worth one more XP than the last. Sounds and music are just for fun.

Plan your theme

What every theme needs

- A name and a square cover
- At least 5 balls (up to 10)

What it can also have

- Background, title, board and side panel pictures
- Colors for buttons, text, pegs and buckets
- New names and pictures for the 4 main power-ups
- New power-ups of its own
- Peg colors with sounds, and one background song

Good power-up rules

- Say what it does in one short sentence.
- It lasts one turn, then it is gone.
- It helps, but nobody wins every time.
- It fits the theme (a dog theme: Super Smell).
- Nothing ever gets hurt. Things can bounce, wobble, poof or float.
- Think about what happens when it is on with Double or Magnet.

Example: Super Smell (a dog theme)

Action	Magnet (pull to the top bucket), with a new name and a dog nose picture.
What it does	The dog sniffs out the best treat bucket and the ball follows its nose.
When it works	Every drop this turn.
How the ball moves	3 in 4 chance on each row to bounce toward the top bucket.
With others	Same as Magnet: works with Big Ball on the rows where it bounces.

Design your own power-up

Fill this in before you draw. If one of the actions in "More actions a theme can use" fits, write it down. If not, write "Something new" and answer every question carefully.

Theme

Power-up name

Action

Amount (if it has one)

What it does

When it works

How the ball moves

With other power-ups

Card text (short)

Picture

Draw it on its power-up page of the theme template, inside the dashed square.